

ungrateful for the thought and effort that people I love have put into a gesture. This is something that seems to be actively encouraged by the society and culture that we live in – dependent as our economy is on people continuing to buy things they don't want or need in order to try to make up for time and connection that they have lost.

In December 2020, Currys PC World put out a Christmas TV advert in the UK that centred around the idea of gifting. The whole premise of the storyline was people giving terrible gifts, and having to witness the disappointment of the people they care about – the items in question were things like board games and stuffed animals. The ad then showed those same people giving expensive electronic gifts to their loved ones, with the solution being presented as Currys PC World's 'buy now, pay later', service in order to finance them. Complaints were made to the Advertising Standards Agency (ASA), and were upheld,⁸ for reasons that are, to be frank, glaringly obvious to me. The report, and the comments from the advertising agency, make very interesting reading. I'll talk more about manipulative advertising in Step Four, but for now, I want to focus on the pre-existing beliefs that the advertisers were hoping to tap into with this campaign.

Most of us worry all the time about whether we are good enough. Good enough at work, good enough for our friends, our children, our partners. And consumer culture presents us with a quick, easy cure for feeling guilty or inadequate – gifts! We're encouraged to replace time and shared experiences